

12th Grade: The Decision Year

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Applications, financial aid, and final choices. The deadlines are real. Here is the year on one page.

AUG
25

Confirm final college list

Reach, match, safety schools confirmed. Use the app comparison tool together.

SEP
1

Have the real budget conversation

What can your family realistically contribute per year? Your student needs to know.

SEP
15

Create your FSA ID NOW

Go to studentaid.gov. You need your own login to co-sign the FAFSA. Don't wait.

OCT
1

FAFSA OPENS TODAY — file immediately

File FAFSA as early as possible. Earlier = earlier aid offers. Cal Grant deadline is March 2.

OCT
1

CA Dream Act Application opens

For undocumented students: CA Dream Act Application opens October 1. Deadline March 2.

NOV
1

Early Decision/Action deadlines

ED/EA applications due Nov 1-15. Discuss financial risk of ED before committing.

JAN
1

Regular Decision deadlines (Jan 1-15)

Most RD applications due January 1 or 15. Confirm your student's specific deadlines.

JAN
15

File taxes ASAP

Early tax filing = FAFSA verification = faster aid offers.

MAR
2

CAL GRANT DEADLINE — TODAY

California Cal Grant requires verified GPA + completed FAFSA by March 2. Do not miss.

APR
1

Admission decisions arrive

Most RD schools notify by April 1. Celebrate every acceptance.

APR
5

Compare financial aid offer letters

Look at: net price, grants vs loans, whether aid renews, total 4-year cost.

APR
20

Appeal financial aid if appropriate

Changed financial situation? Another school offered more? A polite appeal is often worth sending.

MAY
1

NATIONAL COLLEGE DECISION DAY

Enrollment deposit due at chosen school. Celebrate the decision!

JUN
1

Set up student bank account + budget

Before college: bank account, basic budget, and understanding of aid package.

OCT
1

FAFSA renewal reminder (Year 2)

Student must renew FAFSA every year of college. Set this reminder to repeat annually.
